

Κέλσος ὁ Πλατωνικός

Celsus the Platonist and the True Discourse Against Christianity

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Period: *Ῥωμαϊκή* [Roman](#)
Dialect: *Κοινή φιλοσοφική* [Philosophical Koine](#)
Domain: *Φιλοσοφία* [Philosophy](#)
Format: *Πραγματεία* [Treatise](#)
Affiliation: [Platonist](#)

Celsus was a Greek philosopher of the 2nd century CE living within the Roman Empire. He is renowned for authoring a major critique of early Christianity. His precise dates, birthplace, and personal life remain unrecorded. He is generally identified as a Platonist philosopher, though one ancient source also referred to him as an Epicurean. He was clearly well-educated, drawing upon classical Greek philosophy, literature, and Jewish texts to formulate his arguments.

Celsus wrote one known work, **The True Doctrine**, which constitutes a comprehensive attack on Christian beliefs and practices. The original text is lost, but its content is preserved through extensive quotations and summaries within a later refutation written by the Christian theologian Origen of Alexandria. In his work, Celsus argued that Christianity was an irrational superstition that undermined traditional Roman religion and social order. He criticized core Christian doctrines, mocked Christian practices, and asserted that Christian teachings were derivative of older Greek and Jewish ideas.

Celsus holds significant historical importance as the author of the earliest known sophisticated pagan critique of Christianity. According to modern scholars, his reconstructed text provides a crucial window into the intellectual and religious debates of the 2nd century, revealing how educated pagans perceived the growing Christian movement. His arguments represent a key phase in the conflict between traditional Greco-Roman thought and early Christianity.

Works (1)

- [Ἀληθὴς λόγος](#) · [True Discourse](#) · 264 passages

Other Platonist Authors

- [Ἀλβῖνος ὁ Πλατωνικός](#) · [Albinus the Platonist](#) · 2 works
- [Ἀλέξανδρος Λυκοπολίτης](#) · [Alexander of Lycopolis](#) · 1 work
- [Ἀνώνυμος ὑπόμνημα εἰς τὸν Πλάτωνος Θεαίτητον](#) · [Anonymous Commentary on Plato](#) · 1 work
- [Ἀρίμνηστος](#) · [Arimnestus the Philosopher](#) · 1 work
- [Ἀττικός](#) · [Atticus the Philosopher](#) · 1 work
- [Κάσσιος Λογγῖνος](#) · [Cassius Longinus the Philosopher](#) · 3 works

- Κράντωρ ὁ Σολεύς · Crantor of Soli · 2 works
- Ἡρακλείδης ὁ Ποντικός · Heraclides of Pontus · 2 works
- Ἡρακλείδης ὁ Ποντικός · Heraclides of Pontus II · 1 work
- Ἡρακλείδης ὁ Ποντικός · Heraclides of Pontus III · 1 work
- Ἀνώνυμος Προλεγόμενα εἰς τὴν Πλατωνικὴν Φιλοσοφίαν · Introduction Platonism Anonymous · 1 work
- Νουμήνιος ὁ ἐξ Ἀπαμείας · Numenius of Apamea · 1 work